

Affect and effect

Teaching guide

Describe an influence and its result.

Understand the distinction

Affect is usually a verb meaning influence: The noise affected my sleep. Effect is usually a noun meaning a result or influence: The noise had an effect on my sleep.

There are less common meanings: effect can be a formal verb meaning bring about, as in effect change; affect can be a specialist noun about outward emotional expression. Start with the common patterns, but do not treat the spelling distinction as exceptionless. A causal claim still needs evidence.

Compare the patterns

VERB

The delay affected our plans.

Affected tells what the delay did.

NOUN

The delay had an effect on our plans.

Effect is the noun after an.

CAUTIOUS CLAIM

The delay may affect our plans.

May preserves uncertainty.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the verb meaning influence: The weather can ___ travel.

- A. affect
- B. affection
- C. effect

2. Choose the noun meaning result: What ___ did the change have?

- A. affect
- B. effective
- C. effect

3. Is effect never a verb?

- A. No. Effect change means bring change about.
- B. No. As a verb, effect always means notice.
- C. Yes. Effect is only ever a noun.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. The timetable's influence on your journey is uncertain. Which sentence preserves that uncertainty?

- A. The new timetable may affect my journey to work.
- B. The new timetable will definitely shorten my journey to work.
- C. The new timetable may affection my journey to work.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. A. affect

A verb is needed after can.

B: Affection is a noun meaning fondness, not the verb influence.

C: The usual verb meaning influence is affect; effect as a verb means bring about.

2. C. effect

This question asks about the result as a noun.

A: This sentence needs the noun effect meaning result or influence.

B: Effective is an adjective; the question asks what effect the change had.

3. A. No. Effect change means bring change about.

That formal use is less common than the noun.

B: The verb effect means bring about, not notice.

C: Effect can be a formal verb meaning bring about, as in effect change.

4. A. The new timetable may affect my journey to work.

May keeps the outcome possible rather than certain, and affect means influence.

B: This asserts a particular outcome and certainty not provided in the prompt.

C: Affection is a noun, not the verb needed after may.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-38.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

The timetable's influence on your journey is uncertain. Which sentence preserves that uncertainty?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.